

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MAURITANIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the desert, coast, and water of Mauritania — but this guide must begin honestly, because Mauritania is a hard place to oppose a project and there is no landmark community victory to point to. Mauritania's economy runs on extraction: state-owned iron ore in the north, a vast foreign-owned gold mine near the coast, and a new offshore gas field, together with the industrial fishing that presses on one of the world's great bird and fish sanctuaries, the Banc d'Arguin. When communities and workers have pushed back — as when hundreds of workers laid off from the Tasiast gold mine travelled three hundred kilometres to protest outside the presidential palace, only to have their camp raided by police, with a dozen arrested and others injured — the state has more often answered with force than with concession. Civil society is thin and constrained, environmental governance is weak, and the great projects are powerful, foreign-financed, and closely tied to the government's revenues. This guide will not pretend a grassroots win exists where it does not.

The Mauritanian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly and up front. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Mauritanian, and it is what gives this guide its real, if modest, force. **Because Mauritania's great projects are largely foreign-owned and internationally financed — a Canadian gold company, a British-led gas consortium, World Bank guarantees, and a UNESCO World Heritage sanctuary — a community has access to international levers of accountability that domestic channels, on their own, do not provide.** That combination — the environmental law and assessment at home, plus the financiers' standards, the company's home-country obligations, the UNESCO status, and the transparency initiatives abroad — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it.

But the same story carries an honest warning this guide places first and takes seriously, because the difficulty and the danger here are real. **Opposition in Mauritania is hard, constrained, and can be met with repression.** Protest has been raided and protesters arrested; civil society organisations operate under real limits; environmental assessments have been criticised as inadequate or not independent; and the economy's dependence on extraction gives the government and the companies great leverage. The honest record is one of labour disputes and grievances met with force, toxic incidents, and projects that proceed — not of communities stopping mines. This guide does not pretend the path is easy or the odds are good. What it shows is how, in a constrained state whose biggest projects answer to foreign owners, financiers, and international bodies, a community can use those external levers, together with what domestic channels exist, to demand accountability, mitigation, and — rarely — a stop, as safely and effectively as the hard conditions allow.

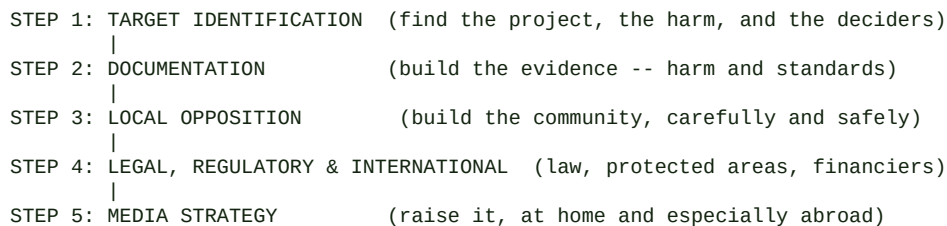
Most communities do not know HOW to reach the levers that a foreign-financed project actually answers to. They hear that a mine or a gas field or a fishing fleet is taking their land, water, or catch, and assume "the government and the company have decided and there is nothing we can do," and never engage the environmental assessment, never file with the financiers' accountability mechanisms, never invoke the

UNESCO status or the transparency initiative. They generate private grievance — or dangerous, unsupported protest — without organised, strategic pressure on the points where these projects are genuinely vulnerable. The gap between projects held to account and projects that answer to no one is here often not apathy but a lack of method, and a lack of safe, effective channels.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Mauritanian system as it is, honestly, including its real dangers and limits. It is written for the person whose land, water, coast, or livelihood is threatened by a mine, a gas project, or an industrial fishing fleet, and who wants to know whether anything can be done in a country where opposition is constrained and sometimes dangerous. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers exist, and the foreign and international ones are real and distinctive, but the domestic space is narrow, the risks are genuine, and there is no grassroots victory to promise you — only accountability to demand, harm to mitigate, and the rare chance of a stop. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it must be used. It is for the person willing to work patiently, strategically, and above all safely — to document rather than to march, to petition an international body rather than to confront the state, to protect their people rather than to expose them. That is not a lesser form of courage but, in Mauritania, the only form that does not end in a police cell, and the only one this guide can responsibly recommend. Anyone imagining that opposition here means a defiant public campaign should understand that such campaigns have been crushed, and that the real, reachable power lies elsewhere — in the standards and bodies these foreign-financed projects answer to abroad. This guide is an honest map of that offshore power, and of how a community can reach it without walking into danger.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to hold a gold or iron mine, a gas project, or an industrial fishing operation to account:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm feeds the environmental assessment, the financiers' complaint, the media, and the international bodies at once; the community organises, carefully; a filing with a financier or a report to UNESCO is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still modest — chance of holding a project to account in a system where such accountability is rare.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Mauritania's — a foreign-financed extractive economy, a world-famous protected sanctuary, and membership in international transparency and standards regimes — give communities a distinctive, underused set:

- **The financiers' standards. World Bank guarantees and international-finance performance standards** carry accountability mechanisms a community can invoke, as Tasiast's international financing does.
- **The company's home country. A foreign owner answers to laws and expectations abroad** — Canadian, British — that reach where local law is weak.

- **The UNESCO sanctuary.** The **Banc d'Arguin World Heritage status** is an international lever against harm to it, near which the gold mine sits.
- **The transparency initiative.** Mauritania's **membership in international transparency regimes** opens the books and creates leverage.
- **The environmental assessment.** The **required Environmental Impact Assessment**, weak as its record is, remains a formal domestic channel.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers reliably work, or that a grassroots victory awaits. There is **no landmark community win** in Mauritania; protest has been **met with force**; civil society is **thin**; environmental governance is **weak**; and the projects are **powerful and government-tied**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them first and throughout, and it puts safety first — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this system offers — above all the international ones — to demand accountability where a stop is rare, honestly acknowledging the danger and the modest odds.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week — and before you take a single risk — map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the project, or the leverage, is weakest. And map what would be lost and where the environmental law, the financiers' standards, the protected-area status, and the international bodies apply, because in Mauritania a destructive project is rarely stopped by domestic protest alone, which can be dangerous, and is best pressed at the international points of accountability where a foreign-financed project is genuinely vulnerable.

The Levels of Decision

A Mauritanian development runs through several tracks at once — some domestic and constrained, some foreign and more open — and each is a place to intervene.

The government. The **state and its agencies** drive and depend on the great projects, above all the state-owned iron ore and the revenues from gold and gas; they are a decider to be pressured through accountability and international leverage, not easily moved by domestic protest, which they have suppressed.

The company and its financiers. The **foreign owner and its international financiers** — a Canadian gold company, a British-led gas consortium, World Bank guarantees — answer to **home-country laws, lender standards, and accountability mechanisms** that a community can reach, and that reach where local law is weak.

The environmental authorities. The **environmental ministry and the required assessment** are the formal domestic channel, weak in record but real in form, through which harm must in principle be considered.

The protected areas and UNESCO. The **Banc d'Arguin National Park and its World Heritage status** are an international lever against harm to that sanctuary and its fishing communities.

The unions, courts, and international bodies. The **labour unions, the courts, and regional and international bodies** — transparency initiatives, human-rights and heritage bodies — are levers, however constrained at home.

The Journey of a Project

A typical mine or gas project moves from an exploration permit and a financing package, through an environmental assessment and approvals, toward construction and decades of operation — with the **community's evidence, the environmental authorities, the financiers' mechanisms, the UNESCO status, and the international bodies** able to intervene. **The financing and assessment stages are where a foreign project is most reachable**, because that is when the international standards bite, and pressing them there is the distinctive Mauritanian approach. The distinctive levers are the **financiers' standards, the home country, the UNESCO sanctuary, the transparency initiative, and the environmental assessment**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what harm it would do, who owns and finances it and to what standards, and which international mechanisms apply**, because those are where a project can most realistically be held to account.

Follow the Project, the Water, and the Deciders

Behind a project stand the government and, usually, a powerful foreign owner and its financiers. Trace who decides, who owns and funds it, and — importantly here — **what harm it would do to land, water, coast, and communities, what standards its financing and home country impose, how it affects the Banc d'Arguin and its fishers, and which international mechanisms apply**. Two questions unlock most Mauritanian efforts: **What harm would be done, and to what standards is the project actually bound?** and **Through which channel — the assessment at home, the financiers, the home country, UNESCO, the transparency bodies abroad — can that harm be pressed?** The international standards and mechanisms are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Mauritanian effort ultimately serves these two: the documentation exists to prove a breach of the standards, the coalition exists to carry that breach safely to the mechanisms, and the media exists to raise its cost before the audiences those mechanisms answer to. Keep the standards and the mechanisms at the center of every filing, every letter, and every story, and the effort retains a clear, external, and reachable spine even when its individual moves are modest and its domestic space is narrow and dangerous.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **environmental ministry and the assessment; the international financiers and their accountability mechanisms; the company's home-country laws and expectations; UNESCO and the Banc d'Arguin; the transparency initiatives** Mauritania belongs to; the **labour unions; the courts; and regional and international human-rights bodies**. In Mauritania, the **financiers' standards, the home country, the UNESCO sanctuary, the transparency initiative, and the environmental assessment** are the most distinctive levers, and the strongest of them reach in from abroad. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to breach international standards, harm a World Heritage sanctuary, or hide its dealings can be pressed at points a purely domestic effort could never reach — though, honestly, the great projects have usually proceeded, and this guide will keep saying so. These are the hard facts of the terrain, and an effort built on them is stronger than one built on hope.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort — or take any risk — calibrate honestly, and here that means acknowledging that success is rare, that domestic protest can be dangerous, and that the strongest levers reach in from abroad. These figures are **directional and deliberately sober** — patterns drawn from how extractive conflicts have mostly gone in Mauritania and comparable states, not a controlled study, and not a promise. The decisive

variables are whether the community can **document real harm against the standards a project is actually bound to**, whether it can **reach the international mechanisms** the domestic ones lack, and whether it can **do so safely**. Where the harm is provable and the project is foreign-financed, the international levers are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that domestic space is narrow, protest has been repressed, governance is weak, and the projects are powerful and government-tied.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–15%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Harm-against-standards case	25–45%	weeks–months	low	The breach, shown to those who can act
Financiers' accountability mechanism	30–50%	months–years	low–moderate	An investigation; mitigation; leverage
UNESCO / protected-area route	25–45%	months–years	low	International pressure on harm to the sanctuary
Home-country / transparency pressure	25–45%	months–years	low	Scrutiny the domestic system cannot apply
Environmental assessment (domestic)	15–35%	months	low–moderate	Harm raised; rarely mitigation or refusal
All steps (foreign-financed, international)	30–50%	months–years	moderate	Accountability, mitigation, rarely a stop
Domestic protest alone	5–20%	days–weeks	high risk	Often repression; seldom a win

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Mauritania's real strengths are the **international** ones: the **financiers' standards**, the **home country**, the **UNESCO sanctuary**, and the **transparency initiative**, with the domestic **environmental assessment** as a weaker complement. Its constraints are specific, honest, and heavy: **domestic space is narrow, protest has been repressed, governance is weak**, and the **projects are powerful and government-tied** — and there is **no grassroots win** to build on.

*A note on cost and risk: the international levers here — a documented case, a complaint to a financier, a report to UNESCO or a transparency body — cost mainly knowledge and persistence rather than money, and, crucially, they can often be pursued more safely than domestic protest, which has been met with force. The scarce resources are **strategic knowledge of the international mechanisms and the courage to use them** — and the safety to do so. Reaching the right external body is worth more here than any amount of domestic noise, and is often less dangerous. Reaching the right external body is worth more here, in the end, than any amount of domestic noise, and is very often far less dangerous. This is, in its way, the quietly hopeful side of an otherwise grim picture: because the decisive resources are documented evidence, strategic knowledge of the international mechanisms, and careful international allies — rather than the numbers and visibility that domestic repression makes dangerous — a small, careful group can wield real leverage without exposing a mass of people to force. A handful of people who document a breach precisely and carry it to the right financier or home-country body can achieve more, and more safely, than a thousand*

exposed in a square. The barrier here is not the size of the crowd but the knowledge of which distant lever to pull and the care to pull it safely — and both are within the reach of a small, determined, well-advised community.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (project held to account, mitigated, or -- rarely -- stopped)

PROVABLE HARM + INTERNATIONAL STANDARDS + FINANCIERS/UNESCO:

All steps combined:	■■■■■■■■■■	30-50%
Financiers' mechanism:	■■■■■■■■■■	30-50%
Harm-against-standards case:	■■■■■■■■■■	25-45%
UNESCO / home-country route:	■■■■■■■■■■	25-45%
Single step:	■■	5-50%

DOMESTIC-ONLY, GOVERNMENT-TIED PROJECT -- narrow, risky space:

All steps combined:	■■■■■	10-25%
Accountability / mitigation:	■■■■■■■■■■	sometimes achievable
The record / the case made:	■■■■■■■■■■	far more reliable than a stop
Domestic protest alone:	■	5-20% and dangerous

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Mauritania are the **international** ones — the financiers' standards, the home country, UNESCO, and transparency — with the domestic assessment a weaker complement, and domestic protest alone both risky and usually futile. The reach of the international mechanisms shows the ceiling: a foreign-financed project bound to real standards can be investigated and pressed from abroad in ways the domestic system cannot match. The repression of the Tasiast workers' protest shows the honest floor: domestic pressure, unsupported by international leverage, was met with a police raid and arrests. Most Mauritanian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the international levers are real and worth using — able to force accountability, win mitigation, and rarely a stop — but that against a government-tied extractive project, the realistic outcome is accountability or a record, not a stop, and that domestic protest carries real danger.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The harm-against-standards case** — Mauritania's foundation; the provable harm measured against the international standards the project is actually bound to.
2. **The financiers' accountability mechanisms** — the distinctive lever; the World Bank and lender complaint channels a foreign-financed project answers to.
3. **The UNESCO and home-country routes** — international pressure on harm to the sanctuary and on the foreign owner.
4. **The transparency initiative** — the leverage that opening the books provides.
5. **The domestic assessment, unions, and courts** — the narrower, weaker home channels, used with care.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The international levers are the real ones** — a foreign-financed project answers to standards and mechanisms a community can reach from outside. **Domestic protest is dangerous and usually futile** — the Tasiast workers' protest was raided and its people arrested. **Governance and assessment are weak** — the great mine's assessment was criticised as inadequate, and toxic incidents occurred. **Accountability is a likelier win than a stop** — harm can sometimes be investigated and mitigated even where a project proceeds. **There is no grassroots victory** — none, honestly, to point to. The through-line: **document real harm against the standards the project is actually**

bound to; reach the international mechanisms — the financiers, the home country, UNESCO, the transparency bodies — that domestic channels lack; do so safely — because a community that does can force accountability, mitigation, and rarely a stop, while being honest that domestic protest is dangerous, the odds are hard, and there is no precedent of a community win.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is above all the international standards a foreign-financed project is bound to. Vague grievance goes nowhere, and unsupported domestic protest can be dangerous; an effort aimed at "the gold mine whose cyanide and water use threaten our land, which is financed by an international lender under performance standards it may be breaching, owned by a company answerable in its home country, and sitting near a World Heritage sanctuary" is a strategic, and safer, effort — the kind that can reach the points where such a project is genuinely vulnerable. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What harm would the project do? This is the first question here. What **harm to land, water, coast, air, and communities** — the cyanide and water of a gold mine, the dust and displacement of an iron mine, the impact of gas or of industrial fishing on the Banc d'Arguin's fishers.

2. Who owns and finances it, and to what standards? Which **foreign company owns it, which international lenders finance it, and which performance standards and home-country obligations** bind them — the distinctive Mauritanian question.

3. Does it harm a protected area? Does the project threaten the **Banc d'Arguin or another protected area**, opening the UNESCO and international-heritage lever.

4. Which international and domestic channels apply? Which of the **financiers' mechanisms, the home country, UNESCO, the transparency initiative, the environmental assessment, the courts, and the unions** can be used — and which can be used safely.

5. Who decides, who profits, and who can help — safely? Which government body, company, and financier are behind it, who profits, and which unions, few civil-society groups, international NGOs, and bodies can help without exposing the community to danger.

A Worked Example

Suppose a foreign-owned gold mine's cyanide and water use threaten a community's land and wells, its assessment thin, its financing international.

Working the five questions: **what harm? Who owns and finances it, to what standards? Does it harm a protected area? Which channels apply, and safely?** And the deciders are the government, the company, and the financiers, with the financiers' standards, the home country, UNESCO, transparency, and the assessment as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the company and the government have decided" to a strategy that reaches where the project is vulnerable: document the harm against the financing standards; file with the financiers' accountability mechanism; raise it with the home country and the transparency bodies; and, carefully, use what domestic channels are safe. That is a strategic, safety-conscious effort suited to Mauritania — not a dangerous protest that force would crush. Notice what the five questions accomplish:

they convert a raw sense of grievance and helplessness — a foreign company is taking our water and the government is on its side — into a set of specific, answerable, and largely external targets, each attached to a lever that lies beyond the reach of domestic repression. The harm becomes documentable evidence. The ownership and financing become named standards to invoke. The protected area becomes a UNESCO lever. The channels become specific international bodies to petition. And the safety question, asked at every step, keeps the effort from tipping into the exposed confrontation that has been crushed before. That translation — from dangerous, futile grievance to a strategic, protected, offshore campaign — is the first and most important thing a Mauritanian effort must do, because it is what moves the fight from ground where the community is weak and exposed to ground where it has real, reachable leverage.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the strongest case is made to international bodies against defined standards, sound, standard-referenced evidence is decisive. A financier's ombudsman, a home-country regulator, a UNESCO committee, a transparency body, and even a weak domestic assessment all move on evidence measured against rules, not on grievance — and in Mauritania, a clear record of the harm, and of how it breaches the standards the project is bound to, is precisely what an effort turns into international leverage, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Owners, and the Standards

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its foreign owner, its international financiers, the land, water, and coast it would take, and the approvals and assessment it requires**; and establish, crucially, **which international performance standards, home-country laws, and lender conditions bind it** — for these are the rules against which harm becomes an actionable breach. Establish the deciders, the owners, and the standards precisely, because the distinctive Mauritanian case is not merely that a project does harm, but that it does harm in breach of standards its own financiers and owners are bound to uphold.

Layer 2: The Harm — to People, Water, and the Sanctuary

Document the harm itself, thoroughly and safely. Establish the **environmental harm** — the cyanide and water use of a gold mine, the dust and land of an iron mine, the effluent of processing, the pressure of industrial fishing on the Banc d'Arguin's fish and fishers — and the **community harm**, including displacement, lost wells and pasture, lost catch, and health effects, as toxic incidents near the gold mine have shown. Gather it carefully, protecting those who provide it, in a state where such documentation can draw hostility. Photographs, water and soil tests, health and catch records, and expert analyses make the harm undeniable — and, measured against the financiers' standards, actionable.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Standards, the Channel, and Safety

Finally, document the case and the plan. Does the **harm** breach the **international standards** the project is bound to? Does it threaten a **protected area**? Which **channel** — the financiers' mechanism, the home country, UNESCO, transparency, the assessment, the courts — is open, and what does it require? And, always, **how can this be done safely**, protecting those involved from a state that has met protest with force? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed at the international points where a foreign-financed project is genuinely vulnerable. This is the layer that most often decides what can be decided here, because a documented harm, a demonstrable breach of binding standards, an open international channel, and a safe way to use it are exactly what give a Mauritanian community leverage

it could reach no other way. Build it well, and the project's own financiers and standards become the community's strongest lever. One practical note on building this layer: the whole strategy depends on identifying, precisely and early, the exact standards a project is bound to, because a vague complaint of harm carries little weight while a documented breach of a named, binding standard is actionable. Is the mine financed by a lender whose performance standards require independent environmental assessment, meaningful community consultation, and specific water and tailings safeguards? Is the owner headquartered in a country whose guidelines for multinational conduct its overseas operations are expected to meet? Is the sanctuary a listed World Heritage site with defined protections? Establish these specific, binding rules first, and then measure the project's conduct against each, so that the case is not 'this project is harmful' but 'this project breaches this named standard in this documented way.' That precision is what transforms a grievance the state can ignore into a complaint an international body must consider, and it is the single most important thing this layer must get right.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Mauritanian effort, and how to get it — with the **harm**, the **binding standards**, and the **international and domestic channels** at the center, and with safety a constant concern. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Owner, and Financing Record

Start with the project itself. **Permits, agreements, and approvals** establish what is intended, though the limited transparency may require persistence — and here the transparency initiative Mauritania belongs to is a real help, since it opens contracts and payments. Identify the **foreign owner and the international financiers** — a Canadian gold company, a British-led gas consortium, World Bank guarantees — and, above all, the **performance standards and lender conditions** attached to the financing, which are often public and are the rules your case will invoke. Establish exactly **what the project is, who owns and funds it, and to what standards it is bound**, because those standards are the community's distinctive leverage.

The Harm Evidence — Gathered Safely

This is the heart of the file, and it must be gathered with care. Document the **environmental harm** — water tests near a gold mine, soil and dust, effluent, the state of a fishery — and the **community harm** — lost wells, pasture, catch, health, displacement, as toxic incidents near the mine have shown. Draw on **independent experts, international NGOs, and the financiers' own disclosure documents**, which often contain admissions of impact. Protect those who gather and provide evidence, since in a constrained state such documentation can draw hostility. Credible, standard-referenced harm evidence is the single most powerful thing this file can contain, precisely because it can be set against the rules the project is bound to.

The Standards and Protected-Area Record

Document the rules and the sanctuary, because these are the distinctive Mauritanian levers. Gather the **international performance standards** attached to the financing, the **home-country obligations** of the foreign owner, and the terms of any **transparency-initiative disclosures**. And, where relevant, document the project's impact on the **Banc d'Arguin World Heritage site** and its Imraguen fishing communities, since harm to a UNESCO sanctuary opens a powerful international lever. A community that can show harm in breach of binding standards, or harm to a World Heritage site, holds leverage a purely domestic grievance never could.

The Channels and Allies

Identify the channels and allies. The **financiers' accountability mechanisms** — the World Bank group's independent complaint offices — are the distinctive channel for a foreign-financed project. The **home-country routes** — the company's own regulators and the international guidelines for multinational conduct — reach the owner abroad. **UNESCO and international heritage and human-rights bodies**, the **transparency initiative**, the **labour unions**, the **courts**, and **international NGOs** are further channels. Map which apply, and which can be used safely, because in Mauritania the international channels reach where domestic ones cannot, and are often less dangerous to use.

The People — and Their Protection

Finally, map the human terrain, with safety foremost. Who is affected — the mine's neighbours, the fishers, the workers, the displaced? Who are the **unions**, the **few civil-society groups**, the **sympathetic experts**, the **international NGOs and bodies**? And, crucially, **how are they protected** — from a state that has raided protests and made arrests? A Mauritanian effort is advanced less by a mass domestic movement, which repression makes dangerous, than by a careful coalition of the affected, the unions where they exist, and the international allies who can press from safer ground — so map that coalition, and its protection, deliberately. A word on each of these allies, because their roles are distinctive here. The affected community supplies the direct, credible testimony without which no international complaint has standing. The unions, constrained as they are, supply an organised and somewhat protected domestic force, as the mine's workers have shown, and their labour grievances often overlap with the community's environmental ones. And the international allies — NGOs, networks, accountability mechanisms, home-country bodies — supply the reach, the expertise, and, crucially, the protection that let a case be pressed from ground safer than Mauritania's own. No one of these is a mass movement, and in Mauritania a mass movement would be dangerous; together, carefully assembled and protected, they are the nearest and safest thing a Mauritanian effort has to real force.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself — but here, more than in most places, "opposition" must be understood with safety foremost, because Mauritania has met domestic protest with force, arrests, and injuries. What moves deciders here is rarely a mass demonstration, which can be dangerous and is easily crushed, but an organised, documented community whose case is carried to the international bodies a project answers to. Mauritania has little safe space for open confrontation; the task is to organise the community's stake into evidence and leverage, and to reach the levers that lie beyond the reach of domestic repression.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Why It Must Be Careful

An international body can act on a documented, organised community complaint; it can do little with an anonymous grievance. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the local and environmental knowledge, the evidence of harm, and the legitimacy that makes an international complaint credible. But in Mauritania this community must act carefully, because the state has answered protest with a police raid and arrests. **A united community here is the effort's engine — but its power is best exercised through documentation and international channels, not through exposed domestic protest that force can crush.** This is the hardest lesson to accept for anyone who imagines opposition as a matter of visible defiance, but in Mauritania it is the difference between an effort that endures and one that ends in a police cell. The Tasiast workers who marched on the presidential palace were not wrong to be aggrieved,

nor cowardly; they were simply exposed, and the state answered their exposure with force. A community that channels the same grievance into a documented complaint to the mine's international financiers, or a report to the company's home country, achieves something the march could not: it reaches a decision-maker that repression cannot silence, and it does so from behind the shield of an international process rather than in the open where force falls. Understand this not as timidity but as strategy — the strategy of a community that means to still be standing, and still pressing its case, a year from now.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the project touches most — the **mine's neighbours whose water and land are threatened, the fishers whose catch is pressed, the workers, the displaced** — whose stake is direct and whose testimony is the heart of any complaint. Widen to those who share the water, the coast, and the land. Name the shared stake — **our water, our land, our catch, our health** — but frame the effort, for safety, as a demand for accountability and adherence to standards, not as a confrontation with the state, because that framing is both safer and more likely to engage the international bodies that can actually act. This framing is not evasion; it is an accurate description of what the effort actually is. A community asking that a foreign-owned mine meet the environmental and social standards its own financiers require is not attacking the Mauritanian state; it is holding a private, foreign project to rules it freely accepted. That distinction matters both for safety — it gives the authorities little pretext to treat the effort as sedition — and for effectiveness, because the international bodies that can act are precisely bodies concerned with standards, financing, and heritage, not with a community's quarrel with its own government. Cast the effort as a demand for accountability to agreed international standards, and you both protect your people and speak the language of the levers that can actually move a foreign-financed project.

Coalition-Building, Safely

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, but the Mauritanian coalition is built with protection in mind. Reach deliberately to the **labour unions**, a real if constrained force, as the mine's workers have shown; the **few civil-society and environmental groups; independent experts**; and — decisively here — **international NGOs and networks** that can carry the case to the financiers, the home country, and UNESCO from safer ground. Frame the coalition as a demand for accountability under the standards the project is bound to, and lean on the international allies to press what domestic actors cannot safely press. Breadth here means international reach as much as local numbers.

Sustaining a Careful Effort

Mauritanian efforts are constrained and can be slow, and sustaining them means sustaining both care and safety. Keep the community **informed, organised, and protected**; mark international steps — a complaint filed, an investigation opened, a mitigation won, a transparency disclosure obtained. And keep it **as safe as possible**, because the state has met protest with force, and an effort that exposes its people to a police raid has failed them however just its cause. Prefer the international and documentary channels, which are both more effective and safer here, to open domestic confrontation. The effort that lasts is the one that stays organised, protected, and focused on the levers that repression cannot reach. Sustaining such an effort demands a particular discipline, because its rewards are slow, external, and often invisible at home. There will rarely be the visible drama of a successful protest; there will be, instead, a complaint acknowledged by a distant ombudsman, an investigation opened, a company quietly required to improve a practice, a transparency disclosure obtained. A community that measures itself only by what changes visibly on the ground, or by a full stop to a project, will despair, because those are rare here. One that learns to value the slow accumulation of international pressure — and to protect its people while that pressure builds — can

endure, and can hand a stronger position to the next community that faces the same companies and financiers. Endurance here is a matter of patient, protected, offshore persistence, not of visible domestic intensity.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & INTERNATIONAL CHALLENGES — THE ENVIRONMENTAL LAW, THE PROTECTED AREAS, AND THE FINANCIERS' STANDARDS

This is where a Mauritanian effort is most realistically advanced — not through domestic protest, which is dangerous, nor mainly through a weak domestic courtroom, but through the **international standards, financiers' mechanisms, and protected-area status** to which a foreign-financed project answers, complemented by what domestic law allows. Here the distinctive Mauritanian levers are external, and a community's task is to reach them.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth, and here it is central. The domestic levers are **weak**: the environmental assessment has been criticised as inadequate or not independent, the courts are constrained, and protest has been repressed. The **international levers are stronger but slow and uncertain**: the financiers' mechanisms can investigate and press but rarely stop a project; the home-country and UNESCO routes apply real pressure but move slowly. What these levers realistically achieve is **investigation, accountability, mitigation, and leverage** — not usually a stop. Enter this front clear-eyed and safety-first: the international standards and mechanisms are Mauritania's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm is provable and the breach of binding standards is clear** — but the realistic outcome is accountability or mitigation, a stop is rare, and domestic confrontation is dangerous.

The Financiers' Standards and Mechanisms

The first and most distinctive front is the financing. A foreign-financed project — Tasiast's international guarantees, a gas project's lenders — is bound to **international performance standards**, and its financiers maintain **independent accountability mechanisms** to which affected communities can file complaints. Establish the standards, document the breach, and **file a complaint with the financier's mechanism** — the World Bank group's independent complaint offices are the classic route. This can trigger an **investigation, a dispute-resolution process, and real pressure for mitigation**, and it is often safer than domestic action because it is pursued through an international body abroad. This is the front to master first, because it reaches where Mauritanian law cannot. Take the time to learn how a given financier's mechanism actually works, because the details determine everything. Some offer a dispute-resolution track, in which the mechanism brings the community and the company together to negotiate remedies; some offer a compliance track, in which it investigates whether the lender's own standards were breached; many offer both, and a community can often pursue them together. Each has its own filing requirements, its own confidentiality protections for complainants, and its own timeline. Understanding these in advance — ideally with the help of an international NGO experienced in such complaints — lets a community file a complaint that the mechanism can accept and act on, rather than one it must reject on a technicality, and lets the community choose the track, and the protections, that best fit its situation and its safety.

The Environmental Law and the Protected Areas

The second front is domestic and heritage law. The **environmental assessment**, weak as its record is, remains a formal channel to raise harm and demand mitigation; engage it, and expose its inadequacies. And where a project threatens the **Banc d'Arguin World Heritage site** or another protected area, invoke the **UNESCO and protected-area lever** — a report to the World Heritage Committee of harm to the sanctuary applies international pressure the domestic system cannot. Use the assessment for what it can yield and the protected-area status for the powerful international leverage it provides, together feeding the financiers' and home-country fronts. A report of harm to the Banc d'Arguin deserves particular care in its preparation, because the World Heritage system responds to well-documented threats to the specific values for which a site was listed. Frame the harm not merely as general environmental damage but as a threat to the sanctuary's listed values — its globally important bird populations, its fish nurseries, the traditional Imraguen fishery — and to the integrity that its status is meant to protect. A report framed in the system's own terms, and supported by credible evidence, is one the World Heritage bodies can take up; a vague complaint of nearby industrial activity is easier to set aside.

The Home Country, Transparency, and the Courts

The third front reaches the owner and the books. The foreign owner answers to its **home country** — Canadian, British — through home regulators and the **international guidelines for multinational conduct**, whose national contact points can hear complaints about a company's overseas conduct. Mauritania's membership in **international transparency initiatives** opens contracts and payments, exposing terms and leverage. And the **domestic courts**, constrained as they are, remain an avenue for the bravest and best-supported cases. These fronts, pursued from the safer ground of international bodies and the company's home country, are how a Mauritanian community reaches accountability that domestic repression would otherwise foreclose. It is worth understanding why these international and domestic fronts reinforce one another, because their combination is the heart of the Mauritanian approach. The domestic assessment and courts, weak as they are, generate the on-the-ground record — the tests, the filings, the official acknowledgements — that the international mechanisms need as evidence. The financiers' standards supply the binding rules against which that record becomes an actionable breach. The home country and UNESCO supply the reputational and heritage pressure that makes the owner and its backers care. And the transparency initiative supplies the documented facts about deals and payments that underpin every other front. Each alone is limited: the domestic front is weak and dangerous, the financiers' mechanism is slow, the home-country and UNESCO routes are indirect. But woven together — a domestic record of harm, measured against binding standards, pressed at the financiers and the home country, amplified by heritage and transparency bodies — they form a web of external accountability that a foreign-financed project cannot easily escape, and that reaches where Mauritanian repression cannot follow.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them — and here, above all, in the language of international standards. The same file of harm and breach becomes different arguments for a financier's ombudsman, a home-country contact point, a UNESCO committee, a transparency body, and the careful domestic channels. Translate deliberately, and always with safety in mind.

For the Financiers' Mechanisms

The financiers' complaint offices respond to **the performance standards and the evidence of breach**. Frame the harm precisely as a failure to meet a named standard: the inadequate assessment, the water or

cyanide impact, the community harm, the missing consultation. Give them the documented breach and ask for investigation, dispute resolution, and mitigation. Make it easy to act within their mandate: *here is the standard, here is the harm, here is the breach*. This is the argument that reaches furthest here.

For the Home Country

The home-country regulators and multinational-conduct contact points respond to **the company's obligations abroad**. Frame the harm as conduct that falls short of what the company's home country expects of it overseas — environmental, labour, human-rights. A Canadian or British company answers, in its own country, to expectations a Mauritanian community can invoke. Give the contact point the documented conduct and the applicable guidelines, so the pressure reaches the owner where it is most sensitive: at home.

For UNESCO and International Bodies

UNESCO and international bodies respond to **harm to what they protect**. Frame harm to the Banc d'Arguin as a threat to a World Heritage site of global significance, and harm to communities as a matter for human-rights bodies. Their concern applies pressure the domestic system cannot, and their voice can say what is dangerous to say at home. Give them the globally significant harm, documented and credible.

For the Careful Domestic Channels

The domestic assessment, courts, and public respond to **evidence and law, cautiously**. Frame the harm for the assessment as a failure it must address, for the courts as a breach of domestic environmental law, and for the public as a threat to shared water, land, and catch — but always with an eye to safety, and always ready to shift the weight to the international levers that repression cannot reach.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never expose your people needlessly. Your credibility is your greatest asset before an international body, and your people's safety is more important than any argument. State the harm precisely, measure it against the standards accurately, and pursue it through the safest effective channel. A community that is precise, credible, and careful — especially about the harm and the standards — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches, and far safer than one that confronts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — but in Mauritania, that pressure works best when it reaches an international audience, and domestic media must be used with care in a constrained press environment. The story — a foreign-financed project harming people, water, and a world sanctuary in breach of its own standards — is one that travels, and travels safest, abroad.

Why Media Matters — Especially Abroad

A foreign company, its financiers, and a reputation-conscious government behave differently when harm is visible internationally. Media does three things here: it **informs and pressures the international bodies and the company's home public**, it **raises the reputational cost** to a foreign owner and its financiers, and it **draws the international attention** that domestic repression cannot silence. Because the great projects answer to foreign owners and financiers, international media and the company's home-country press are unusually powerful levers, reaching where the constrained domestic press cannot. A harm made visible to a company's home public is a harm its owners cannot easily ignore. This is why the home-country and

international press deserve particular emphasis in a Mauritanian effort. A foreign mining or energy company operates in Mauritania largely out of sight of the public, shareholders, and regulators of its home country, and that invisibility is part of what allows harm to go unaddressed. Bringing a documented, credible account of that harm to the company's home audience — to the newspapers, the investors, the regulators who can actually affect it — collapses the distance that protected it, and forces owners and financiers to answer at home for conduct they preferred to keep offshore. Cultivate these international and home-country outlets with accuracy and care, giving them documented harm they can stand behind, because their reach turns a distant Mauritanian grievance into a reputational problem a foreign company must manage.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the harm and the broken standard. The strongest frame is concrete and internationally legible: a *foreign-owned project is harming our water, our land, and a world heritage sanctuary — in breach of the very standards its financiers and home country require of it*. Put the human and environmental harm first, and the breach of international standards close behind, because that breach is what engages the international audience and the accountability bodies. Keep it scrupulously accurate; before an international body and a foreign press, overstatement is quickly caught and discredits the case.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to safety. **International media and the company's home-country press** for the reputational and accountability pressure that reaches furthest; **international NGO networks** for amplification and protection; **the transparency initiative's disclosures** for documented leverage; and the **domestic press only with care**, given its constraints and the risks to those who speak. Because Mauritania's projects answer abroad, the international and home-country channels are the ones that matter most — and are often the safest.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, credible, and safe — the goal is international accountability, not a domestic confrontation that force would crush. Protect individuals above all, in a state that has arrested protesters; prefer collective, international, and documentary voice to exposed domestic protest or named local spokespeople who could be targeted. Handle the foreign companies and the government factually, not with invective, because credibility before international bodies depends on it. And sustain the effort patiently, because international accountability moves slowly. Above all, let the harm and the breach of standards, carried to an international audience, do the work — because that is where a Mauritanian effort is both most effective and most safe.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real standards, keep it factual, and protect those involved. Here precision against standards, and safety, matter more than force.

8A: Requesting Information and the Assessment

Subject: Request for information — [project], environmental assessment and standards

Dear [official/company],

I write on behalf of [community/group] regarding [project] at [location]. To engage constructively, we request the **Environmental and Social Impact Assessment**, the **approvals**, information on the **land, water, and**

coast affected, and the **international performance standards and lender conditions** attached to the project's financing. We wish to ensure the project meets the standards to which it is committed.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Complaint to a Financier's Accountability Mechanism

Subject: Complaint regarding [project] — breach of performance standards

To the [independent accountability mechanism],

We, [community/group] affected by [project], financed by [lender], submit this complaint. The project causes [harm — water, land, health, displacement], which we believe breaches [named performance standards], including inadequate [assessment/consultation/mitigation]. We request an investigation and, as appropriate, dispute resolution and mitigation. We attach our documentation, and ask that the safety and confidentiality of complainants be protected.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Letter to a Home-Country Contact Point

Subject: Concern regarding [company]'s conduct at [project] in Mauritania

To the [National Contact Point / regulator],

We write regarding the conduct of [company], headquartered in [country], at its [project] in Mauritania, which causes [harm]. We believe this conduct falls short of [the multinational-conduct guidelines / home-country expectations], and we respectfully request that this be examined. We attach documentation and request that the safety of those who provided it be protected.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Report to UNESCO / an International Body

Subject: Threat to the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage site from [project]

Dear [World Heritage Centre / body],

We write to report that [project] threatens [the Banc d'Arguin World Heritage site / protected area] and the Imraguen fishing communities that depend on it, through [harm]. Given the global significance of this sanctuary, we respectfully request your attention and, as appropriate, your engagement with the authorities. We can provide documentation of the harm.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch (International)

Subject: Foreign-owned project harming Mauritanian communities and a world sanctuary

Dear [journalist],

At [location] in Mauritania, [project], owned by [company] of [country] and financed by [lender], is harming [water/land/fishers/the Banc d'Arguin] — in apparent breach of the international standards its financiers and home country require. There is a clear, internationally significant story here — the harm, the foreign owner, the broken standards. We can provide documentation and, with due care for their safety, voices.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Coalition Outreach (International NGOs)

Subject: Support for a Mauritanian community facing [project]

Dear [organisation],

We are [group], a community harmed by [project], owned and financed internationally. We seek your support in carrying our case to the financiers, the company's home country, and international bodies, from ground safer than our own. Your reach and protection would strengthen an effort that domestic conditions make dangerous. May we discuss working together?

In solidarity,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter to a Labour Union

Subject: Standing together on [project]

Dear [union],

Our community, and the workers at [project], share a stake in how it treats people and the environment. We have documented [harm — environmental, community, labour]. We hope to work with you to press, safely and through proper channels, for accountability and mitigation, as workers' concerns at the mine have been raised before. Might we meet to discuss a common, careful approach?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Informing the Community (Carefully)

Subject: Our water, our land — and how we can seek accountability safely

Dear neighbours,

[Project] threatens our [water/land/catch/health]. We know that open protest here has been met with force, so we are pursuing accountability through safer, stronger channels — the project's international financiers, its home country, and world bodies — which the project must answer to. Please share, carefully and safely, what you know of the harm, so that together we can demand that this project meet the standards it is bound to, without exposing anyone to danger.

With respect and care,

[Name, community group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is moving fast — an approval near, works imminent — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the financiers' standards, an international ally, and documented harm.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — safely: **what the project is, what harm it would do, who owns and finances it, and to what standards**. Identify the immediate channel — a **financing decision, an assessment window, a lender's process** — because that is what you must reach first. Contact **an international NGO or a union** that can act from safer ground, because in Mauritania an ally who can carry the case abroad is the fastest and safest route to leverage.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others here, though none is fast. **A documented harm measured against the financing standards** can open a complaint quickly. **A complaint to a financier's accountability mechanism** starts an international process. **An alert to an international NGO or the company's home-country press** draws attention repression cannot silence. **A report of harm to the Banc d'Arguin** engages UNESCO. These international levers outpace — and are safer than — domestic protest, which force can crush in hours.

Emergency Coalition-Building — Safely

You cannot build a broad coalition overnight, and open domestic mobilisation is dangerous. But you can activate a fast, safer one: the **affected community's documented testimony, a union, an international NGO, and a financier's or home-country channel**. A handful of credible, protected voices carrying documented harm to an international body, at the right moment, is the most a rapid Mauritanian effort can safely do — and often the most effective. Speed favours the prepared: know your harm, your standards, your international channel, and your people's safety before the deadline.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted from the outset — by an economy dependent on extraction, a government that shares in the projects' revenues, a constrained civil society, and a record of meeting protest with force. This is Mauritania's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level here would be both false and unsafe.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are the ordinary condition of Mauritanian extraction. The **projects are central to state revenue**, and the government is a partner in or beneficiary of them. **Civil society is thin and constrained**, and independent voices are few. **Protest has been repressed** — raided, its people arrested. **Environmental governance is weak**, and assessments have been criticised as inadequate. This is not a tilt a domestic movement can simply overpower; it is the structure an effort here must be built for, which is why this guide leans so heavily on the international levers.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted and domestic space is narrow and dangerous, take the fight to where the project is vulnerable: **abroad**. Lean on the **financiers' mechanisms**, the **home country**, **UNESCO**, and the **transparency initiative** — the levers that reach in from outside and that repression cannot silence. Aim realistically at **accountability, mitigation, and a documented international record**, which are achievable, rather than at a stop, which is rare. Protect your people by preferring these external, documentary channels to exposed domestic protest. And build the record even when you cannot win, because a documented breach lodged with an international body shifts the next financing, the next assessment, and the company's reputation. A tilted field here does not so much lengthen the odds as move the fight offshore — and the international levers are where a Mauritanian community's real, if modest, power lies. There is a further reason this offshore strategy is not merely a fallback but genuinely the community's strongest position, particular to a foreign-financed extractive economy. The very features that make the domestic field so tilted — the projects' dependence on foreign ownership, international financing, and export markets — are also what create the external vulnerabilities. A purely domestic project, financed and owned at home, would answer to no one but a captured domestic system; but a project owned by a listed foreign company, financed by an international lender with an accountability mechanism, selling into scrutinised global markets, is exposed at a dozen points abroad. The community's task is to recognise that the project's foreign character, so intimidating up close, is precisely its weakness at a distance — and to press, patiently and safely, at those distant points of exposure that the project cannot escape by controlling the ground at home.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may well lose, and this guide will not pretend otherwise — here, losing is a likely outcome, as the great projects that proceeded despite harm and repression attest. If the project proceeds, the work is still not wasted: the **harm was documented, the breach of standards lodged with those who can act, the record made, and the next effort — and the slow pressure on financiers and companies to do better — starts a little stronger**. International accountability is incremental; each documented breach raises the cost of the next. Fight, safely and strategically, to hold a foreign-financed project to its own standards; if you lose, lose in a way that leaves an international record and protects your people. This longer, incremental view is not consolation so much as an accurate account of how accountability grows around foreign-financed extraction. Each complaint lodged with a financier, each home-country filing, each UNESCO report, each transparency disclosure raises the cost and the scrutiny attached to the next project, and builds a documented history that later communities, journalists, and regulators can draw on. The great Mauritanian mines were financed and built in an environment of weak scrutiny; every documented breach lodged with an international body helps make that environment a little less permissive, a little more accountable, for the projects and communities that come after. Seen this way, an effort that fails to stop a project but succeeds in lodging a credible international record of its harm is not a defeat but a contribution to a slowly tightening accountability — and, in a system this tilted, that is a real and honourable form of winning.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Mauritania, unlike some places, the question of corruption and capture is a real and serious one, and it must be approached carefully, because raising it carries risk. Weak governance, opaque deals, and a state entwined with the projects' revenues create real possibilities of capture — but proving it is dangerous and difficult, and an unsupported accusation can expose those who make it.

Telling Capture from Ordinary Tilt

A government that depends on extraction and shares its revenues is tilted, but not necessarily corrupt; the ordinary tilt is a structural dependence, not a crime. Capture shows sharper marks: **deals hidden without lawful basis, assessments waved through against evidence, enforcement suspended for the powerful, and the suppression of those who ask questions**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish structural dependence from provable corruption**, and do not level accusations the evidence does not support, especially where doing so is dangerous. The transparency initiative Mauritania belongs to is the safest tool here, because it can expose deals and payments through an established international process rather than through a dangerous domestic accusation.

Responding to Capture — Carefully

Where capture is real, the response is the international one, pursued safely. Use the **transparency initiative** to expose the deals and payments through its established channels. Take documented evidence of corruption to the **financiers' mechanisms and the home country**, whose anti-corruption rules bind the foreign owner. Rely on **international anti-corruption and investigative bodies and journalists**, who can pursue from safer ground what is dangerous to pursue at home. Document meticulously and protect sources, because in a captured and constrained system the evidence is both the weapon and the risk. The aim is to route the exposure through international channels that repression cannot reach — never through an exposed domestic confrontation.

A Note on Safety and Care

This is the guide's most important note, and it applies throughout, not only here. Mauritania has met protest with force — a raided camp, arrests, injuries — and pursuing accountability, especially where it touches corruption, carries real risk. So keep the effort **documentary, international, collective, and protected**. Prefer the international channels, which are both safer and stronger, to exposed domestic action. Protect individuals — never let a single named person carry a public burden that could make them a target; use collective and international voice instead. Seek the protection of international NGOs and accountability mechanisms, which can shield complainants. Safety is not caution at the expense of the cause; here, it is the condition of the cause continuing at all, and of the people the cause is meant to serve coming to no harm.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, careful effort against a destructive project in Mauritania.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, carefully. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-breach file. **Target identification** aims it at the owners, financiers, and standards. **Local opposition** organises the community's stake, safely. **Legal, regulatory, and international** work presses the financiers, the home country, UNESCO, and what domestic law allows. **Media** carries it to an international audience. The harm and the breach of standards feed all five at once — a documented harm is evidence for a financier's complaint, a home-country filing, a UNESCO report, and an international story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, where the strongest levers are external, they must reach outward together. The compounding matters especially in Mauritania, because no single lever is strong enough to rely on and the domestic ones are dangerous besides. Consider how a single

well-documented harm — a contaminated well near a gold mine, say — travels across all five fronts at once: it is, in the same season, evidence for a complaint to the mine's international financiers, a matter for the company's home-country contact point, a data point for the transparency initiative, a story for the international press, and, cautiously, a filing in the domestic assessment. A community pressing only one of these, especially only a domestic one, would likely see it absorbed, dismissed, or repressed; a community pressing all of them together makes the harm impossible to bury on every side at once, and shifts the fight to the external ground where it is both safer and stronger. In a system where each lever is modest and the domestic space is hazardous, this mutual reinforcement across international fronts is not a refinement but the whole strategy.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the project, the harm, the owners, and the standards; document safely; identify the international channels and allies. **Middle (months 2–12):** build the case and the protected coalition; file with the financiers' mechanism; engage the home country, UNESCO, and the transparency initiative; carry the story to an international audience. **Later (months and years):** press the international processes for investigation, accountability, and mitigation, and build the record whatever the outcome. A Mauritanian effort is patient, external, and often slow, and its likeliest fruit is accountability or mitigation rather than a stop; pace the effort, and one's hopes, accordingly — and keep safety foremost throughout. A practical way to pace it is to fix one's expectations on the achievable and the safe, and to treat anything beyond as an unlooked-for gift. Set out to document the harm credibly, to lodge it with the international bodies that must consider it, to win concrete mitigation of the worst impacts, and to leave a durable international record — these are genuinely within reach, and each is a real service to the community and to those who come after. If, beyond them, a project is delayed or, rarely, stopped, so much the better; but an effort that stakes everything on that rare outcome, or that risks its people to pursue it, will likely end in disillusion or danger, while one that values the achievable and protects its people will end having done real good and harmed no one. In Mauritania, calibrating one's hopes honestly, and one's risks carefully, is not defeatism; it is the condition of an effort that helps rather than endangers.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm and the breach of the standards the project is bound to; reach the international levers — the financiers, the home country, UNESCO, transparency — that domestic channels lack; protect your people; and keep every claim precise.** The community that presses all five, safely and strategically, gives itself the modest but real chance that Mauritania's foreign-financed projects allow — to win accountability, mitigation, a documented record, and rarely a stop — while holding, throughout, to the honest truths that there is no grassroots precedent, that domestic protest is dangerous, and that the odds are hard.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing a destructive development in Mauritania is genuinely difficult and sometimes dangerous, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no grassroots victory to point to, protest has been met with force, and the great projects have usually proceeded. And yet the effort is not futile, because Mauritania's biggest projects answer not only to a constrained domestic system but to foreign owners, international financiers, world heritage bodies, and transparency regimes — and those external levers are real, reachable, and often safer than confronting the state at home.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The international levers — the financiers' standards, the home country, UNESCO, transparency — are the real ones, and they reach where domestic channels and repression cannot. A documented breach of binding standards is the community's strongest weapon. But domestic space is narrow and dangerous, governance is weak, the projects are government-tied, and the likeliest outcome is accountability or mitigation, not a stop.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, external levers, and honestly hard and hazardous conditions.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the safety — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm and the broken standard. Reach the financiers, the home country, UNESCO, and the transparency bodies. Protect your people, and prefer the safer international channels to exposed domestic protest. And keep every claim precise, because before an international body, credibility is everything, and for a Mauritanian community, safety is everything. Never let the pursuit of a just cause cost the very people it is meant to protect; in Mauritania, an effort that keeps its people safe while patiently building international accountability has already done something real, whatever the final fate of the project.

The Tasiast workers who travelled three hundred kilometres to protest were met with a police raid and arrests; toxic waste was dumped near a community; assessments were criticised as inadequate; and the mines and the gas project went ahead. This guide has hidden none of it. But those same projects answer, whether they like it or not, to financiers with standards, to owners with home countries, to a world that treasures the Banc d'Arguin, and to transparency regimes that open the books — and there, at those external points of accountability, a Mauritanian community has leverage that repression cannot reach and that no purely domestic grievance could ever hold. There is no easy victory to promise you, and no grassroots precedent to inherit; There is, in the end, no easy victory to promise you, and no grassroots precedent to inherit; this guide has said so throughout. But your water, your land, your catch, and your health are worth defending, the standards these projects are bound to are real and enforceable from abroad, and the careful, documented, international effort to hold them to those standards — pursued safely — is one worth making. The power here lies offshore, in the standards and bodies these projects answer to. The intimidating scale of a foreign mine or gas field up close is, at a distance, its exposure: a project answerable to financiers, home-country regulators, heritage bodies, and transparency regimes is a project with many places it can be held to account, if a community knows where to press and does so safely. Reach it carefully, and you reach the one real lever a Mauritanian community holds. That lever is not nothing. A foreign-owned, internationally financed project is bound, whether it wishes to be or not, by standards it accepted, by the laws of its owner's home, by the protections around a world sanctuary, and by the transparency regimes its host has joined — and every one of those bindings is a handle a community can grasp from ground that repression cannot reach. Grasp them carefully, document meticulously, protect your people, and press patiently through the international bodies these projects must answer to, and you will have done, for your water and land and coast, the most that can honestly and safely be done in Mauritania — and perhaps a little more than has been done before.